

A ROOM BUILT IN THE HALLWAY

On tires, care, and the firewall between them
Imran Hafiz · The Auxiliary

In 2017, two things happened in advertising that I think about almost every week, though I only worked on one of them.

The one I didn't work on was the Pepsi commercial with Kendall Jenner. You remember it. A protest of indeterminate cause, beautiful young people of carefully calibrated demographics, a line of riot police, and Kendall — pulled from a photo shoot by some telepathy the ad never explained — handing a cop a can of Pepsi. The cop drinks it. The protesters cheer. Something has been resolved, though it is never clear what. The ad was pulled in forty-eight hours. Pepsi apologized. Kendall cried on her family's reality show. The machine that produced it was not a machine that could be fired; it was the machine itself.

The other thing that happened in 2017, which nobody remembers because it was small and it worked, was a short film called *Inroads to the Community*. I wrote it. I was a Junior Creative at VIRTUE, which was VICE's in-house agency. My creative director was a guy named Tyler Pierce, who was good at his job in the specific way that mattered for what I'm about to tell you, which is that he let juniors run with ideas if the ideas were any good, and he didn't steal credit, and he didn't flinch when the ideas required telling a client something the client didn't want to hear.

The client was Michelin. The brief, handed to us in a single declarative sentence I have never forgotten, was this:

SHOW HOW TIRES = CARE.

I want to stay with that sentence for a second, because it is perfect. It is the entire condition of contemporary brand marketing compressed into four words and a math operator. A tire is a physical object that grips a road. Care is an orientation of the human heart toward the wellbeing of another. The equals sign is doing more work than any equals sign has ever done in the history of semiotics. What Michelin was asking for was this: *make people feel that our rubber donuts are actually a form of love, and do it in a way we can put on a reel.*

This is, if you think about it for more than four seconds, an impossible brief. It is also the brief every brand is running right now, in one variant or another. Show how oil = stewardship. Show how fast

fashion = self-expression. Show how the algorithm = connection. The equals sign is always there, and the equals sign is always lying, and everyone in the room knows the equals sign is lying, and the job — the actual job, the one they hire you for — is to make the lie beautiful enough that nobody has to say so out loud.

I've taken to calling this condition **the Pretend Era**, for reasons that will become clear by the end of this essay. The Pretend Era is not a moral failure of individuals. It is a rational equilibrium. Everyone inside it knows the game is broken; nobody can be the first to say so, because the cost of being the first defector is borne entirely by the first defector. So the meetings continue. The briefs get written. The equals signs proliferate. Pepsi happens. And then another Pepsi happens.

There is a way out. I want to tell you about it by telling you what happened in the Michelin meeting, because the way out revealed itself to me there, and I have spent the nine years since trying to figure out what the rule was that made it work, so it could be made to work again, on purpose, at scale, by people who are not me.

But first I have to tell you the thing I knew walking into that meeting that Michelin did not know about itself.

The thing I knew was this: most people under thirty-five have no idea that the Michelin Guide — the red book, the stars, the entire global apparatus of culinary legitimacy — is published by the same company that makes the tires on their Honda Civic. The guide was invented in 1900 by the Michelin brothers, who wanted to give early French motorists a reason to drive further, which would wear out their tires faster, which would sell more tires. It is, in its original conception, the single most elegant piece of content marketing in history, and it has been running for a hundred and twenty-five years, and most of the people who care about it today do not know it has anything to do with rubber.

I walked into the Michelin meeting knowing this. Michelin, I slowly realized, did not. Or rather: they knew it institutionally, the way you know your own middle name, but they had stopped *feeling* it. They had been lost in brand-world sauce long enough that the guide and the tire company had become, in their internal experience, two psychologically separate enterprises, and the question of whether a twenty-four-year-old in Brooklyn understood the connection had simply never come up, because nobody in the room was twenty-four and nobody in the room was in Brooklyn and nobody had thought to ask.

I asked. I said, more or less, *I don't think young people know the guide is you*. And the room went through the specific silence that happens when an emperor is told about his new clothes by a junior creative who probably shouldn't have been in the room in the first place. It was not a hostile silence. It was recognition — of a thing that had been sitting in the corner of everyone's peripheral vision for a long time, finally named, and once named, impossible to unname.

That was the moment the brief changed, though nobody would have said so out loud. The brief on paper was still *show how tires = care*. The brief in the room, from that moment on, was: **how do we**

become legible again to the people who are supposed to care about us?

And the answer was not going to come from another equals sign. It was going to come from showing up somewhere the brand had no obvious right to be, and earning the right to be there by doing something useful, and letting the usefulness be the message, because the usefulness was the only message that couldn't be faked.

Which is where the chef comes in.

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I interviewed a few chefs before I landed on Carlo Mirarchi. Carlo runs Roberta's in Bushwick, and the associated tasting-menu restaurant Blanca, which holds two Michelin stars and serves about twelve people a night in a room behind the pizza ovens. I picked Carlo for one reason: when I explained the idea, he said yes before I finished explaining it. Other chefs said yes in the careful way chefs say yes to things that might eat a weekend. Carlo said yes the way you say yes to a thing you were already going to do and were just waiting for someone to call and ask. That kind of yes is a signal, and I have learned to trust it above almost any other signal in creative work.

The idea was to bring Michelin-starred chefs to the Grand Central Food Program, which is the largest mobile food kitchen in the world and which I'm going to assume you have never heard of. The GCFP runs a fleet of vans out of the Coalition for the Homeless and serves hot meals to unhoused and food-insecure New Yorkers along routes that have been running, nightly, for decades. Hundreds of meals a night. Every night.

My idea was that the chefs would cook for the GCFP. Not a gala. Not a fundraiser with a step-and-repeat. The actual food, on the actual vans, on an actual night. And the film would not be about Michelin. It would be about the vans, and the chefs, and the food, and the people eating the food. Michelin would appear the way a good host appears at a dinner party — visible enough that you know whose house you are in, invisible enough that you are not thinking about them while you eat.

When I pitched this, the senior client from Michelin's North American operation — whose name I am going to leave out of this essay because I genuinely cannot remember it and because he deserves better than my faulty memory — said the thing that has stayed with me longer than anything else anyone said in the project. He said:

**"WE DON'T FEEL WE HAVE THE RIGHT
TO SPEAK IN THIS SPACE."**

That sentence is the whole game. It is why Michelin came to VICE in the first place — they knew they needed to be culturally legible, they knew the old Michelin Man campaigns weren't going to get them there — and it is also why they had been fighting the idea from the moment I put it on the table. They didn't think they had earned the right to show up where real human suffering was being

addressed by real humans. They were afraid of looking like they were renting moral weight they hadn't paid for. They were, in the specific way career brand people at legacy companies can be, genuinely careful about it. Not defensive. Careful. There is a difference, and I have learned to respect the difference.

What I said to him was something like: *you earn the right to speak in this space by showing up and solving problems. Not by having a position. By being useful. And if you're worried the Michelin Star is too luxurious an artifact to bring into a soup kitchen, consider that Massimo Bottura runs Food for Soul and has been cooking for refugees and the unhoused in Italy for years using the same techniques he uses at Osteria Francescana. Consider that José Andrés runs World Central Kitchen and has fed more people in disaster zones than most governments. These are two of the most Michelin-decorated chefs alive, and nobody thinks their stars got smaller because they used them to feed hungry people. If anything the stars got bigger. The star is not a fragile object.*

He thought about it. Then he said okay. Not an enthusiastic okay. A cautious, *we will see how this goes* okay — the kind that means *I am giving you enough rope to either hang yourself or show me something I haven't seen, and I genuinely do not know which.* Which, for my money, is the most honest kind of okay a senior client can give a junior creative.



The shoot happened on a night I remember as cold but probably wasn't that cold, because memory exaggerates weather when it is trying to tell you something else. Carlo had come earlier in the day — this is the part of the story that took me a while to appreciate — not to perform chef-ness for the camera, but to stand next to the GCFP's regular kitchen crew while they made food. The GCFP's kitchen is run by people who are committed in the way that people who have been doing a hard thing for a long time are committed, and who are also, mostly, not formally trained cooks. They produce hot meals in the kind of batches that would break a restaurant. Carlo gave notes. He tasted things. He suggested a little more salt in one place and a different finishing technique in another. The food that went out that night was their food, cooked by them, with the quiet benefit of someone who runs a two-star kitchen standing next to them for a few hours and helping them make their own work a little better. This is, I would later come to believe, a more accurate picture of what expertise is actually for than almost anything I have seen before or since.

That night, the vans ran their normal routes. The food went out the back doors, pre-plated, handed to people who had come to the stops the vans always go to, at the times the vans always come. Nothing was staged for us. We were joining the work.

The senior client showed up in person. He did not have to. A senior client at a legacy industrial company does not typically show up in Harlem at nine o'clock at night to watch a shoot he has been skeptical of for three months. But he came. He was wearing the kind of expensive Patagonia-type jacket that American corporate men wear when they are trying to signal they are ready for weather,

which is its own small form of care and worth noticing.

I watched him watch it. He stood off to the side and watched the crew open the back of a van and hand out plates of food — food Carlo had helped season that afternoon — to people who had come to the stop because they were hungry and because the van was where the van was supposed to be. At some point during the night, he turned to me and said:

**"I DIDN'T UNDERSTAND WHY THIS MIGHT WORK
UNTIL TODAY. NOW I GET IT."**

I have thought about that sentence more than any other sentence anyone has ever said to me about my work. Not because it was flattering — it wasn't, particularly; it was honest, which is rarer and more useful. I have thought about it because of the phrase *until today*. Three months of meetings, three months of me explaining, three months of references to Bottura and Andrés and arguments about cultural capital — none of it had produced the understanding. What produced the understanding was standing in the cold on a sidewalk in Harlem watching food go out the back of a van to a person who needed it.

The understanding was not available in the conference room. It was only available at the site of the thing itself.

This is, I think, the most important thing I learned in my twenties about how institutional change actually happens: **you cannot explain your way to it. You can only stand next to someone while it happens to them.** The meeting is for permission. The site is for understanding. Confusing the two is the single most common mistake made by people who want to change how large organizations behave.

After that night, I don't remember him fighting the project again.

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The film aired. It was fine. It did what films like that do, which is get a reasonable amount of attention for a reasonable amount of time and then recede into the archive of things brands have made about themselves. If the story ended there, you would not be reading this essay.

The story ends, or rather begins, with the tires.

Because here is the thing I architected into the project that nobody asked me to architect, and which I am probably most proud of in a career that has since involved a lot of things I am proud of: **I made sure Michelin donated tires to the GCFP van fleet.** Not as a PR add-on. As the actual deliverable. The vans needed tires. Tires are expensive. The GCFP operates on margins that would make an accountant weep. And Michelin makes tires. So I wrote into the project that part of what Michelin was doing, in addition to the film, was putting new tires on the fleet.

Notice what this does to the brief. The brief was *show how tires = care*. The film showed chefs cooking food, which is a metaphor for care. But the tires themselves, the actual rubber donuts, were now literally keeping the vans on the road that delivered the food. In this specific context, in the most literal way, **tires equaled care**. The metaphor collapsed into the thing itself. The equals sign stopped lying.

This is the part that took me nine years to fully understand. The reason the project worked was not that we made a good film. A lot of films are good and most do not produce vans. The reason it worked was that somewhere in the middle of the process, the brand's product and the brand's stated value got physically connected to each other through the body of someone who needed help. The tire wasn't standing in for care. The tire was *doing* care, in the form of not going flat, which allowed the van to keep running, which allowed the food to keep arriving. The marketing and the material world were, for one brief moment, the same thing.

A few months after the film aired, I got an email from the director of the GCFP. He asked if I would go back to Michelin and ask them for a van. Not tires for a van. An entire new van. So the GCFP could open a new route in the Bronx.

I wrote the ask. I argued the project had demonstrated what Michelin's capital could do when it stopped trying to buy the *appearance* of care and started buying the *infrastructure* of care. I argued that a van in the Bronx was a better investment than any ad unit they could place against the same budget, because a van in the Bronx would still be feeding people in five years, in ten years, in twenty years, and no ad unit ever made has that kind of half-life.

Michelin said yes. They bought the van. The GCFP opened the Bronx route. And as of my last information [VERIFY with GCFP director] that van is still running that route, hundreds of meals a night, nine years later, because someone at a tire company signed a purchase order in 2017 and the vehicle did what vehicles do when they are taken care of, which is keep going.

I did not win a Cannes Lion for this project. I did not, in fact, win anything. If you google *Inroads to the Community Michelin 2017* you will find roughly what you deserve to find, which is not very much. And yet there is a van in the Bronx that exists because of a meeting I sat in as a Junior Creative, and the van fed somebody dinner tonight, and it will feed somebody dinner tomorrow, and this is the only metric for creative work that has ever actually made sense to me.

It took me the rest of the decade to figure out why.

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Here is the part where I try to tell you what I figured out, and here is also the part where I have to tell you that the thing I was slow to understand was not the project — I understood the project fine — but the thing the project was evidence of.

The thing I was slow to understand was myself.

For most of my twenties and the first part of my thirties, I kept getting told, by people who meant it kindly and by people who didn't, that I was too something for whatever room I was currently in. Too activist for journalism. Too journalist for brand work. Too media-theory for the people who had to ship things by Friday, and too operational for the people who wrote about media theory in journals that came out twice a year. I had gone to Duke to study public policy and economics and had somehow drifted into cryptography and media theory on the way out. Then I had drifted into documentary work at VICE — I was an intern doing associate-producer-level work on the HBO team that won an Emmy, and after that they invited me onto the pre-launch VICE News crew. Then I drifted into advertising at VIRTUE, which is VICE's agency and which, while everyone was looking at the cultural pyrotechnics of the media side, had quietly become the underappreciated engine of financial stability holding up the whole operation. VIRTUE is on the ad agency A-list now. It is, depending on how you count, one of the only pieces of the VICE empire still standing. I spent the better part of a decade inside it — story researcher, junior creative, strategist, insights publisher — and had a hand in shaping what it became.

I mention this not as a flex but because it is the setup for the thing I was slow to understand, which is this: every one of the people who told me I was too something for whatever room I was in was **not wrong about me**. They were wrong about the category. They were assuming a world in which journalism and brand work and media theory were separate disciplines with separate rooms, and in that world I was genuinely a bad fit for all three. What I could not see, because I was too busy trying to squeeze into one room and prove I belonged there, was that the separation between the rooms was the thing that was broken. The rooms had been built for a world in which information moved one way and institutions held monopolies on legitimacy, and that world was already gone, and nobody in any of the rooms had noticed yet, because the people in each room were too busy defending the walls of their own room to look at the hallway.

The hallway, in 2017, was called VIRTUE. The hallway was where the journalism instincts met the brand budgets met the media-theory brain, and the hallway was also — and this is the part nobody wants to admit — the part of the building that was actually paying the rent, while the people in the rooms argued about who owned the building. The Michelin project happened in the hallway. It could not have happened in any of the rooms. A journalism room would have rejected the sponsor. A brand room would have rejected the rigor. A media-theory room would have rejected the shipping deadline. The hallway tolerated all three because the hallway had no walls and could not reject anything on principle. The hallway could only ask whether the thing worked.

I spent the next several years trying to figure out what the hallway was, exactly. I had help: a pandemic.

In the spring of 2020, the world went into a form of collective institutional stress-test that the people running the relevant institutions turned out to be, in the most important respects, unready for. I am not going to catalog the failures because you remember them and because cataloging them in 2026 has become its own small form of Pretend Era theater. What I will say is that the thing I noticed, watching the crisis-response institutions try to communicate in real time with a population whose information environment had changed completely between 2005 and 2020, was that the most junior brand strategist at VIRTUE — earning roughly a fifth of what a senior FEMA communications officer earned — had a more accurate working model of how information actually moved through a networked population than the institutions whose literal job it was to move information through a networked population in a crisis.

This was not because the brand strategist was smart and the FEMA officer was dumb. The FEMA officer was almost certainly smarter and more experienced and had credentials the brand strategist did not have. What the brand strategist had was ten years of operating inside the actual information environment — watching how narratives traveled, which ones got stuck, which messengers were trusted and which were instantly rejected. The FEMA officer had been trained in a model where you wrote the correct message and transmitted it through authoritative channels, and that model had been obsolete for about fifteen years, and nobody inside FEMA could see that it was obsolete because the entire institutional logic of FEMA was downstream of the assumption that the model worked. You cannot see the water you are swimming in. The tragedy of the institutions in 2020 was not that they were staffed by bad people. It was that they were staffed by smart and committed people working inside a model of how the world worked that the world had stopped working according to, and nobody inside had the standing to say so, because saying so would have required dismantling the premise that kept everyone inside employed.

That was the moment I stopped trying to squeeze into rooms.

I built a company. I called it **The Auxiliary**, because the word means *the thing that helps the main engine run when the main engine cannot run on its own*, and because I had become convinced — watching 2020, remembering 2017 — that the main engines of public-interest work in this country were not going to come back the way they had been, and somebody needed to be building the thing that ran alongside them while they figured out what came next. The Auxiliary is an applied mechanism design lab, which is a phrase I use carefully and which deserves its own essay, because this one is already long. What I will tell you is that The Auxiliary exists to do on purpose the thing the Michelin project did by accident: to sit in the hallway between disciplines and produce outcomes that none of the disciplines on their own could produce.

THE AUXILIARY IS A ROOM BUILT IN THE HALLWAY.

One more thing I want to name, and then I will land this.

I have been describing a condition all the way through this piece without quite naming it, and I want to name it now, because naming things is half the work. The condition — where everyone in the room knows the pitch deck is nonsense but nobody can be the first to say so, where brands perform care they do not have the infrastructure to deliver, where institutions optimize for the appearance of function because appearing to function is cheaper than functioning, where the information environment has changed completely but the org charts have not, where we all sit in meetings nodding at things we know are not going to work because the cost of being the first to object is borne entirely by the first objector — I call that condition **the Pretend Era**. I did not invent the dynamic; Timur Kuran wrote the canonical book about the underlying mechanism in 1995 and called it preference falsification. What I have done is notice that the dynamic has metastasized out of politics and into roughly every institution I have ever worked inside, and that if you look at the last decade of public-interest failure through that lens, most of the failures stop looking like incompetence and start looking like a rational equilibrium nobody wanted but nobody could unilaterally exit.

The way out of a rational equilibrium nobody wants is not more exhortation. Exhortation is what got us here. The way out is **mechanism**: a set of rules that changes the payoff structure so that the thing everybody privately wants becomes the thing it is individually rational to do publicly. That is what I have been building. I call the larger framework **the Switchboard**, and it is a ten-step sequence for how trust actually gets built and spent in public life. I am not going to walk you through all ten steps in this essay, because this essay is not the right container for them. I will tell you the one step that matters for the argument I started this essay with, which is the step where brands and sponsors and the holders of concentrated private capital come in.

In a decade when the old institutions are not going to come back the way they were, and the new institutions have not been built yet, and the money to build them is sitting in private hands that have been trained by a quarter-century of CSR theater to spend it on performances of care rather than the material conditions of care, the question of how private capital enters public-interest work is not a side question. It is the question. The oligarchs already own the brands, the media, the publishing companies, the ad agencies, the foundations, and the political system. It is in their actual long-term interest that things keep working in this country. Rory Sutherland has written well about the short-termism that hobbles them from acting on that interest. I am writing about the mechanism that would let them act on it without destroying the thing they are trying to help.

The answer CSR has given us — where the brand commissions the work, shapes the work, approves the work, and ends up with a piece of content that rings hollow to every viewer because the hollowness is a structural property of the commissioning relationship — is the wrong answer. Pepsi in 2017 was the wrong answer. Gillette in 2019 was the wrong answer, preachy and well-meant and instantly rejected. Bud Light in 2023 was the wrong answer in both directions at once, which only a truly broken mechanism can pull off — a brand punished by one audience for a gesture that did not meaningfully help the other audience it was aimed at, because the gesture was never connected to any infrastructure that could have done anything for anyone. The brand had rented the appearance of

allyship without building any of the pipes through which allyship would have had to travel to become real. And everybody, on every side, could feel the hollowness.

Here is the rule I learned from the Michelin project and have spent nine years trying to formalize:

**BRANDS CANNOT BE ALLOWED TO COMMISSION
PUBLIC-INTEREST WORK. THEY CAN ONLY
AMPLIFY WORK THAT HAS ALREADY BEEN
INDEPENDENTLY IDEATED.**

The research, the listening, the truth-finding, the artistic conception — all of it has to happen in a space the sponsor cannot touch, funded by institutions whose job is funding exactly that kind of thing: foundations, universities, public-health bodies, philanthropies that still remember what they were for. The sponsor enters late, at the amplification stage, and what the sponsor buys is not editorial control. What the sponsor buys is **proximity to legitimacy that already exists** — legitimacy the sponsor could never have manufactured on its own, because the manufacturing process required their absence.

This sounds like a restriction. It is actually a gift. It routes each kind of money to the stage where that kind of money is productive. Foundation capital is good at funding diagnosis and ideation and rigor, because that is what foundation capital was invented to fund. Brand capital is good at funding scale and distribution and cultural penetration, because that is what brand capital was invented to fund. The firewall between the two stages is not there to keep brands out of good work. It is there to make sure that when the brand finally enters, the thing they are amplifying is still worth amplifying. Under CSR, brands pay retail for something that only exists at wholesale under non-commissioned conditions, and they are baffled when the thing they paid for does not work. Under the firewall, the brand pays wholesale and the work works, because the work was allowed to exist before the brand arrived.

The Michelin project was an accidental proof of concept for this rule. The GCFP existed, and had existed for decades, and was not invented by Michelin and could not have been invented by Michelin. What Michelin did — what I, a junior creative who did not know he was building a mechanism, got them to do — was show up late, after the work was already good, and help the work travel further than it could travel on its own. Tires for the vans. A new van for the Bronx route. A film that pointed attention at the thing without pretending the brand had built the thing. The brand did not commission the care. The brand amplified care that was already happening, and in doing so, earned the right to be associated with it — which was the thing the brand had wanted from the beginning and had been trying to get through the wrong door for years.

So here is the question I want to leave you with, if you run a brand or sit on a foundation board or sign checks that are supposed to make the world a little better, or if you are the person in any of those rooms who has started to suspect that the rooms themselves are the problem:

There is a van in the Bronx that has been running for nine years because somebody once said yes to the second version of that question without realizing they had been asked it.

■ END // COSTLY SIGNALS ■
■ Imran Hafiz · The Auxiliary ■